



The Battle of Palo Alto, the first battle of the Mexican War, fought near Brownsville, Texas. The war was triggered by a boundary dispute.

DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS BETWEEN MEXICO AND THE US

became strained after Texas became the 28th state (see 1845). The Mexican government did not want to accept this annexation and refuted the US claim that the new state's southern border was at the Rio Grande, stating it lay farther north, at the Nueces River. A diplomatic mission was sent to Mexico City in 1845 to settle the matter, as well as to attempt the purchase of the New Mexico and California territories, but these efforts were met with a snub. The following year, on April 25, Mexican troops crossed the Rio Grande and attacked soldiers stationed there. The US President, **James K. Polk** (1795–1849) declared war, and fighting lasted until Mexico surrendered in 1847.

The US also faced **boundary** disputes with the British, over the Oregon Territory, which lay between 42° N and 54°40' N. The US claim for land as far north as 54°40' N gave rise to Polk's campaign slogan of "Fifty-four Forty or Fight!" However, under the 1846 **Treaty of Oregon** the boundary was set at 49°N.

In Britain, the control of the import and export of grains—known as the **Corn Laws**—had been the source of controversy

for decades. Poor harvests, blockades, and disruption to supplies during wartime had led to fluctuating wheat prices. Legislation to protect domestic agriculture by limiting the **import** of cheap grain and fix prices had proved unpopular and led to the establishment of the **Anti-Corn Law League** in 1839. The League argued that the laws impeded prosperity as restrictions on grain imports caused a price increase and a consequent rise in the cost of wages. The control of exports also limited the external market for British goods. A combination of pressure from the League and the failure of the potato crop in Ireland (see 1845) led to the repeal of the laws.

In **Japan**, there was international pressure for the **isolationist nation** to open up its ports to foreign trade. The Dutch, who were the only Europeans allowed limited access to trade in Japan, sent a mission in 1844 urging the country's rulers to open up trade. This was followed by the French and British requesting trading rights. In 1846, a US delegation arrived and was also sent away empty-handed, but the US would soon try again in its quest for access to Japanese ports (see 1853).



Rebellion of Abd al-Qadir

Although the Algerian troops were hugely outnumbered by the French, Abd al-Qadir made effective use of guerilla tactics.

IN THE YEARS FOLLOWING FRANCE'S ATTACK and colonization of **Algiers** (see 1830), the French faced much resistance from Algerians, including emir **Abd al-Qadir al-Jaza'iri** (1807–1883). He gained the support of Algerian tribes who aided him in his fight against the French. After a series of defeats, he was forced to **surrender** in 1847. He was taken prisoner, but was later freed.

In Germany, a **telegraph** line connecting Frankfurt to Berlin was installed by a firm owned by **Werner Siemens** (1816–92), who had developed a technique for seamless insulation of copper wire.

Meanwhile, English author **Emily Brontë** (1818–48) published *Wuthering Heights*. Although not met with much critical acclaim, it later became one of the most influential literary examples of the **Romanticism** movement.



A poster from 1848, showing the Parisian public facing the municipal guards during the February revolution against the government.

FRIEDRICH ENGELS AND KARL MARX

(see 1844) joined a revolutionary group of Germans known as the League of the Just who soon changed their name to the **Communist League**. Engels and Marx were charged with developing a program of action for the group, and the result was a pamphlet that became known as the **Communist Manifesto**. This called for the overthrow of the bourgeoisie, with the cry of "working men of all countries, unite." Marx believed the gulf between rich and poor in Europe meant conditions were ripe for a socialist revolution.

In February, only a couple of weeks after the manifesto's publication, the streets of **Paris** erupted into revolution. Although it was dramatic and violent, it was not a socialist insurrection. **France** had been suffering an economic depression and a minister named **François Guizot** had come to symbolize the government's inability to alleviate the situation. The monarchy fared little better as the king, **Louis-Philippe** (see 1830), was also very unpopular with the public. Fighting broke out on February 22 and quickly became violent, with soldiers opening fire on the

Europe in revolt

Republican uprisings in 1848 saw an end to the monarchy in France, although revolutionaries in other countries were less successful in their aims.



“ FIFTY-FOUR FORTY OR FIGHT! ”

William Allen, Governor of Ohio, during his election campaign

Protectionist **Corn Laws** abolished in Britain after years of protest

Second Carlist War fought in Spain between Carlist forces and Isabella II's forces

September 23 Planet **Neptune** observed for first time by German astronomers **Johann Gottfried Galle** and **Heinrich Louis d'Arrest**

Sewing machine patented by **Elias Howe** in the US

Ottoman Empire cedes **Abadan Island** in Iran to **Persian Empire**

July 26 **Liberia** gains independence

Resistance to French in **Algeria**

January 24 **James W. Marshall** finds gold in California

February 2 US-Mexican War formally ends

German philosophers **Karl Marx** (1818–83) and **Friedrich Engels** (1820–95) publish **Communist Manifesto**

March 15 Hungarian revolution begins

May 19 Treaty of **Guadalupe Hidalgo** grants US a vast area from Mexico

April 10 Chartist rally of working class demand franchise in London

Tu Duc (1829–83) takes throne of Annam (Vietnam)